

Q What pregnancy complaints might I come across?

You might be lucky and experience none or only some mild complaints during your pregnancy. Complaints can range from small things that are just plain annoying such as yeast, to more debilitating conditions, such as severe morning sickness. Whatever you are experiencing, remember that it will soon pass. You will quickly forget the heartburn or indigestion that pregnancy brings once you're holding your newborn. However, if you are experiencing a complaint that is too difficult to deal with then ask your doctor for advice.

Headaches

» What, when, and how often?

A heavy, pounding head is common in pregnancy—especially if you were prone to headaches during your periods. Headaches are most common in the early stages of pregnancy and usually don't follow any particular pattern or confine themselves to one part of the head. Later on they can be related to anxiety about birth and parenthood.

» What causes them?

Hormonal changes in your body are probably responsible, although feelings of stress about your pregnancy and fatigue can exacerbate the problem.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

Mild pregnancy headaches have no implications for your long-term health nor for the health of your baby: they're simply a side effect of what's going on in your changing body. However, if headaches are severe and long lasting, and/or occur later in pregnancy, they could be a sign of preeclampsia, and occasionally headaches in pregnancy indicate a stroke, so talk to your doctor if you're concerned.

» What can I do?

If your headache is bad, you may be able to take acetaminophen, but call your doctor to find out. Stay hydrated, get lots of rest, and limit your caffeine intake. If that doesn't resolve a headache, consult your doctor.

Low iron/anemia

» What, when, and how often?

Iron is the mineral that carries oxygen in your blood. It also helps to build and maintain muscles. The burden of pregnancy can cause your iron levels to drop in early pregnancy. When your iron levels are so low that you are deficient (measured as having less than 11 g of iron per liter of blood), you have anemia. This occurs in almost 22 percent of pregnancies in the US. Low iron levels make you feel lethargic and sometimes dizzy.

» What causes it?

A vegan or vegetarian diet can cause low iron levels, since meat and dairy products are the body's main sources. If you've had babies close together, your reserves will be depleted at the start of your second pregnancy. If you're carrying more than one baby, you're likely to suffer too.

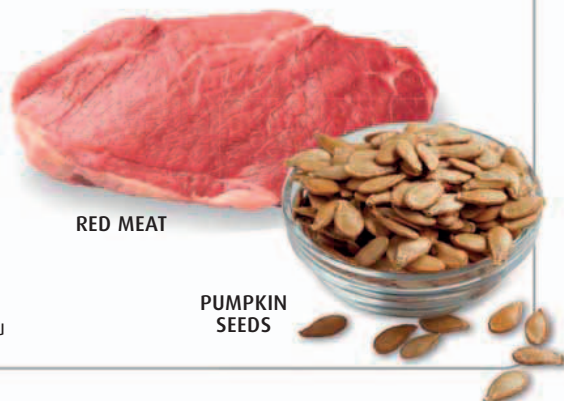
» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

Your body will prioritize the baby's iron (oxygen) requirements over yours, so you'll feel the symptoms of low iron before there's any danger to your baby. You

have a slightly increased risk of having a low birth weight baby or going into labor early.

» What can I do?

Your doctor may prescribe supplements. However, don't take supplements without medical supervision, since having too much iron in your blood can be toxic. Otherwise, try to get plenty of rest and eat lots of iron-rich foods as well as foods rich in vitamin C, which helps your body absorb iron.



RED MEAT

PUMPKIN SEEDS

Dizziness and breathlessness

» What, when, and how often?

Dizziness, dizzy spells, and breathlessness can occur frequently for women during pregnancy. If you experience frequent dizziness, if you've fainted or had a blackout, or if symptoms are accompanied by swelling in the legs, then inform your doctor as soon as possible.

» What causes it?

In your first trimester dizziness can happen because there's not enough of a blood supply to fill your rapidly expanding circulatory system. In your second trimester it is likely to be caused by the pressure of your expanding uterus on your blood vessels. Dizziness can also be caused by low blood sugar, dehydration, or if you're feeling too hot. When you stand up too quickly it's caused by a quick change of blood flow away from the brain. Breathlessness is caused by your expanding uterus pushing everything upward, leaving your lungs with less room to expand when you take a deep breath. High levels of progesterone also increase your breathing rate.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

If you faint or feel dizzy on a regular basis then it might be a sign of anemia. Feeling dizzy every now and then isn't a cause for concern and won't affect your baby. It's completely normal to experience breathlessness and it doesn't harm you or your baby.

» What can I do?

Make sure you stay well-hydrated, get up slowly from lying down or a seated position, keep your blood sugar up, and avoid overheating. If you do feel like you're going to faint then try to increase the blood flow to your brain.

Overheating

» What, when, and how often?

Pregnant women often find they have hot hands and feet and are prone to their faces flushing.

» What causes it?

Increased blood supply to your skin and extremities, hormone changes, and the effort of carrying extra weight.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

Feeling hot is just part of being pregnant and isn't an indication of anything that can harm you or your baby.

» What can I do?

Wear loose cotton clothing, pop your feet or hands in a bowl of cold water, and try to keep your rooms cool.